

A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns in a dark green color, framing the central text.

**BibInVs MN 45**

**Romans**

*Bible Translation:  
Interverse MSG/NIV - 45*

**God**

# Table of Contents

|                           |
|---------------------------|
| <a href="#">Romans 1</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 2</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 3</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 4</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 5</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 6</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 7</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 8</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 9</a>  |
| <a href="#">Romans 10</a> |
| <a href="#">Romans 11</a> |
| <a href="#">Romans 12</a> |
| <a href="#">Romans 13</a> |
| <a href="#">Romans 14</a> |
| <a href="#">Romans 15</a> |
| <a href="#">Romans 16</a> |

# Interversed Message/NIV Bible

## Romans

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### **Romans 1**

MSG

NIV

- 1 I, Paul, am a devoted slave of Jesus Christ on assignment, authorized as an apostle to proclaim God's words and acts. I write this letter to all the Christians in Rome, God's friends.
- 1 Paul, a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle and set apart for the gospel of God--
- 2 The sacred writings contain preliminary reports by the prophets
- 2 the gospel he promised beforehand through his prophets in the Holy Scriptures
- 3 on God's Son. His descent from David roots him in history;
- 3 regarding his Son, who as to his human nature was a descendant of David,
- 4 his unique identity as Son of God was shown by the Spirit when Jesus was raised from the dead, setting him apart as the Messiah, our Master.
- 4 and who through the Spirit of holiness was declared with power to be the Son of God by his resurrection from the dead: Jesus Christ our Lord.
- 5 Through him we received both the generous gift of his life and the urgent task of passing it on to others who receive it by entering into obedient trust in Jesus.
- 5 Through him and for his name's sake, we received grace and apostleship to call people from among all the Gentiles to the obedience that comes from faith.
- 6 You are who you are through this gift and call of Jesus Christ!
- 6 And you also are among those who are called to belong to Jesus Christ.
- 7 And I greet you now with all the generosity of God our Father and our Master Jesus, the Messiah.
- 7 To all in Rome who are loved by God and called to be saints: Grace and peace to you from God our Father and from the Lord Jesus Christ.

- 8 I thank God through Jesus for every one of you. That's first. People everywhere keep telling me about your lives of faith, and every time I hear them, I thank him.
- 8 First, I thank my God through Jesus Christ for all of you, because your faith is being reported all over the world.
- 9 And God, whom I so love to worship and serve by spreading the good news of his Son--the Message!--knows that every time I think of you
- 9 God, whom I serve with my whole heart in preaching the gospel of his Son, is my witness how constantly I remember you
- 10 in my prayers, which is practically all the time, I ask him to clear the way for me to come and see you.
- 10 in my prayers at all times; and I pray that now at last by God's will the way may be opened for me to come to you.
- 11 The longer this waiting goes on, the deeper the ache. I so want to be there to deliver God's gift in person and watch you grow stronger right before my eyes!
- 11 I long to see you so that I may impart to you some spiritual gift to make you strong--
- 12 But don't think I'm not expecting to get something out of this, too! You have as much to give me as I do to you.
- 12 that is, that you and I may be mutually encouraged by each other's faith.
- 13 Please don't misinterpret my failure to visit you, friends. You have no idea how many times I've made plans for Rome. I've been determined to get some personal enjoyment out of God's work among you, as I have in so many other non-Jewish towns and communities. But something has always come up and prevented it.
- 13 I do not want you to be unaware, brothers, that I planned many times to come to you (but have been prevented from doing so until now) in order that I might have a harvest among you, just as I have had among the other Gentiles.
- 14 Everyone I meet--it matters little whether they're mannered or rude, smart or simple--deepens my sense of interdependence and obligation.
- 14 I am obligated both to Greeks and non-Greeks, both to the wise and the foolish.
- 15 And that's why I can't wait to get to you in Rome, preaching this wonderful good news of God.

- 15 That is why I am so eager to preach the gospel also to you who are at Rome.
- 16 It's news I'm most proud to proclaim, this extraordinary Message of God's powerful plan to rescue everyone who trusts him, starting with Jews and then right on to everyone else!
- 16 I am not ashamed of the gospel, because it is the power of God for the salvation of everyone who believes: first for the Jew, then for the Gentile.
- 17 God's way of putting people right shows up in the acts of faith, confirming what Scripture has said all along: "The person in right standing before God by trusting him really lives."
- 17 For in the gospel a righteousness from God is revealed, a righteousness that is by faith from first to last, just as it is written: "The righteous will live by faith."
- 18 But God's angry displeasure erupts as acts of human mistrust and wrongdoing and lying accumulate, as people try to put a shroud over truth.
- 18 The wrath of God is being revealed from heaven against all the godlessness and wickedness of men who suppress the truth by their wickedness,
- 19 But the basic reality of God is plain enough. Open your eyes and there it is!
- 19 since what may be known about God is plain to them, because God has made it plain to them.
- 20 By taking a long and thoughtful look at what God has created, people have always been able to see what their eyes as such can't see: eternal power, for instance, and the mystery of his divine being. So nobody has a good excuse.
- 20 For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities--his eternal power and divine nature--have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that men are without excuse.
- 21 What happened was this: People knew God perfectly well, but when they didn't treat him like God, refusing to worship him, they trivialized themselves into silliness and confusion so that there was neither sense nor direction left in their lives.

- 21 For although they knew God, they neither glorified him as God nor gave thanks to him, but their thinking became futile and their foolish hearts were darkened.
- 22 They pretended to know it all, but were illiterate regarding life.
- 22 Although they claimed to be wise, they became fools
- 23 They traded the glory of God who holds the whole world in his hands for cheap figurines you can buy at any roadside stand.
- 23 and exchanged the glory of the immortal God for images made to look like mortal man and birds and animals and reptiles.
- 24 So God said, in effect, "If that's what you want, that's what you get." It wasn't long before they were living in a pigpen, smeared with filth, filthy inside and out.
- 24 Therefore God gave them over in the sinful desires of their hearts to sexual impurity for the degrading of their bodies with one another.
- 25 And all this because they traded the true God for a fake god, and worshiped the god they made instead of the God who made them--the God we bless, the God who blesses us. Oh, yes!
- 25 They exchanged the truth of God for a lie, and worshiped and served created things rather than the Creator--who is forever praised. Amen.
- 26 Worse followed. Refusing to know God, they soon didn't know how to be human either--women didn't know how to be women, men didn't know how to be men.
- 26 Because of this, God gave them over to shameful lusts. Even their women exchanged natural relations for unnatural ones.
- 27 Sexually confused, they abused and defiled one another, women with women, men with men--all lust, no love. And then they paid for it, oh, how they paid for it--emptied of God and love, godless and loveless wretches.
- 27 In the same way the men also abandoned natural relations with women and were inflamed with lust for one another. Men committed indecent acts with other men, and received in themselves the due penalty for their perversion.
- 28 Since they didn't bother to acknowledge God, God quit bothering them and let them run loose.
- 28 Furthermore, since they did not think it worthwhile to retain the knowledge of God, he gave them over to a depraved mind, to do what

ought not to be done.

- 29 And then all hell broke loose: rampant evil, grabbing and grasping, vicious backstabbing. They made life hell on earth with their envy, wanton killing, bickering, and cheating. Look at them: mean-spirited, venomous,
- 29 They have become filled with every kind of wickedness, evil, greed and depravity. They are full of envy, murder, strife, deceit and malice. They are gossips,
- 30 fork-tongued God-bashers. Bullies, swaggerers, insufferable windbags! They keep inventing new ways of wrecking lives. They ditch their parents when they get in the way.
- 30 slanderers, God-haters, insolent, arrogant and boastful; they invent ways of doing evil; they disobey their parents;
- 31 Stupid, slimy, cruel, cold-blooded.
- 31 they are senseless, faithless, heartless, ruthless.
- 32 And it's not as if they don't know better. They know perfectly well they're spitting in God's face. And they don't care--worse, they hand out prizes to those who do the worst things best!
- 32 Although they know God's righteous decree that those who do such things deserve death, they not only continue to do these very things but also approve of those who practice them.

## **Romans 2**

MSG

NIV

- 1 Those people are on a dark spiral downward. But if you think that leaves you on the high ground where you can point your finger at others, think again. Every time you criticize someone, you condemn yourself. It takes one to know one. Judgmental criticism of others is a well-known way of escaping detection in your own crimes and misdemeanors.
- 1 You, therefore, have no excuse, you who pass judgment on someone else, for at whatever point you judge the other, you are condemning yourself, because you who pass judgment do the same things.
- 2 But God isn't so easily diverted. He sees right through all such smoke screens and holds you to what you've done.

- 2 Now we know that God's judgment against those who do such things is based on truth.
- 3 You didn't think, did you, that just by pointing your finger at others you would distract God from seeing all your misdoings and from coming down on you hard?
- 3 So when you, a mere man, pass judgment on them and yet do the same things, do you think you will escape God's judgment?
- 4 Or did you think that because he's such a nice God, he'd let you off the hook? Better think this one through from the beginning. God is kind, but he's not soft. In kindness he takes us firmly by the hand and leads us into a radical life-change.
- 4 Or do you show contempt for the riches of his kindness, tolerance and patience, not realizing that God's kindness leads you toward repentance?
- 5 You're not getting by with anything. Every refusal and avoidance of God adds fuel to the fire. The day is coming when it's going to blaze hot and high, God's fiery and righteous judgment.
- 5 But because of your stubbornness and your unrepentant heart, you are storing up wrath against yourself for the day of God's wrath, when his righteous judgment will be revealed.
- 6 Make no mistake: In the end you get what's coming to you--
- 6 God "will give to each person according to what he has done."
- 7 Real Life for those who work on God's side,
- 7 To those who by persistence in doing good seek glory, honor and immortality, he will give eternal life.
- 8 but to those who insist on getting their own way and take the path of least resistance, Fire!
- 8 But for those who are self-seeking and who reject the truth and follow evil, there will be wrath and anger.
- 9 If you go against the grain, you get splinters, regardless of which neighborhood you're from, what your parents taught you, what schools you attended.
- 9 There will be trouble and distress for every human being who does evil: first for the Jew, then for the Gentile;
- 10 But if you embrace the way God does things, there are wonderful payoffs, again without regard to where you are from or how you were brought up.

- 10 but glory, honor and peace for everyone who does good: first for the Jew, then for the Gentile.
- 11 Being a Jew won't give you an automatic stamp of approval. God pays no attention to what others say (or what you think) about you. He makes up his own mind.
- 11 For God does not show favoritism.
- 12 If you sin without knowing what you're doing, God takes that into account. But if you sin knowing full well what you're doing, that's a different story entirely.
- 12 All who sin apart from the law will also perish apart from the law, and all who sin under the law will be judged by the law.
- 13 Merely hearing God's law is a waste of your time if you don't do what he commands. Doing, not hearing, is what makes the difference with God.
- 13 For it is not those who hear the law who are righteous in God's sight, but it is those who obey the law who will be declared righteous.
- 14 When outsiders who have never heard of God's law follow it more or less by instinct, they confirm its truth by their obedience.
- 14 (Indeed, when Gentiles, who do not have the law, do by nature things required by the law, they are a law for themselves, even though they do not have the law,
- 15 They show that God's law is not something alien, imposed on us from without, but woven into the very fabric of our creation. There is something deep within them that echoes God's yes and no, right and wrong.
- 15 since they show that the requirements of the law are written on their hearts, their consciences also bearing witness, and their thoughts now accusing, now even defending them.)
- 16 Their response to God's yes and no will become public knowledge on the day God makes his final decision about every man and woman. The Message from God that I proclaim through Jesus Christ takes into account all these differences.
- 16 This will take place on the day when God will judge men's secrets through Jesus Christ, as my gospel declares.
- 17 If you're brought up Jewish, don't assume that you can lean back in the arms of your religion and take it easy, feeling smug because you're an

- insider to God's revelation,
- 17 Now you, if you call yourself a Jew; if you rely on the law and brag about your relationship to God;
- 18 a connoisseur of the best things of God, informed on the latest doctrines!
- 18 if you know his will and approve of what is superior because you are instructed by the law;
- 19 I have a special word of caution for you who are sure that you have it all together yourselves and, because you know God's revealed Word inside and out,
- 19 if you are convinced that you are a guide for the blind, a light for those who are in the dark,
- 20 feel qualified to guide others through their blind alleys and dark nights and confused emotions to God.
- 20 an instructor of the foolish, a teacher of infants, because you have in the law the embodiment of knowledge and truth--
- 21 While you are guiding others, who is going to guide you? I'm quite serious. While preaching "Don't steal!" are you going to rob people blind? Who would suspect you?
- 21 you, then, who teach others, do you not teach yourself? You who preach against stealing, do you steal?
- 22 The same with adultery. The same with idolatry.
- 22 You who say that people should not commit adultery, do you commit adultery? You who abhor idols, do you rob temples?
- 23 You can get by with almost anything if you front it with eloquent talk about God and his law.
- 23 You who brag about the law, do you dishonor God by breaking the law?
- 24 The line from Scripture, "It's because of you Jews that the outsiders are down on God," shows it's an old problem that isn't going to go away.
- 24 As it is written: "God's name is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you."
- 25 Circumcision, the surgical ritual that marks you as a Jew, is great if you live in accord with God's law. But if you don't, it's worse than not being circumcised.
- 25 Circumcision has value if you observe the law, but if you break the law, you have become as though you had not been circumcised.

- 26 The reverse is also true: The uncircumcised who keep God's ways are as good as the circumcised--
- 26 If those who are not circumcised keep the law's requirements, will they not be regarded as though they were circumcised?
- 27 in fact, better. Better to keep God's law uncircumcised than break it circumcised.
- 27 The one who is not circumcised physically and yet obeys the law will condemn you who, even though you have the written code and circumcision, are a lawbreaker.
- 28 Don't you see: It's not the cut of a knife that makes a Jew.
- 28 A man is not a Jew if he is only one outwardly, nor is circumcision merely outward and physical.
- 29 You become a Jew by who you are. It's the mark of God on your heart, not of a knife on your skin, that makes a Jew. And recognition comes from God, not legalistic critics.
- 29 No, a man is a Jew if he is one inwardly; and circumcision is circumcision of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the written code. Such a man's praise is not from men, but from God.

## **Romans 3**

MSG

NIV

- 1 So what difference does it make who's a Jew and who isn't, who has been trained in God's ways and who hasn't?
- 1 What advantage, then, is there in being a Jew, or what value is there in circumcision?
- 2 As it turns out, it makes a lot of difference--but not the difference so many have assumed. First, there's the matter of being put in charge of writing down and caring for God's revelation, these Holy Scriptures.
- 2 Much in every way! First of all, they have been entrusted with the very words of God.
- 3 So, what if, in the course of doing that, some of those Jews abandoned their post? God didn't abandon them. Do you think their faithlessness cancels out his faithfulness?

- 3 What if some did not have faith? Will their lack of faith nullify God's faithfulness?
- 4 Not on your life! Depend on it: God keeps his word even when the whole world is lying through its teeth. Scripture says the same: Your words stand fast and true; Rejection doesn't faze you.
- 4 Not at all! Let God be true, and every man a liar. As it is written: "So that you may be proved right when you speak and prevail when you judge."
- 5 But if our wrongdoing only underlines and confirms God's rightdoing, shouldn't we be commended for helping out? Since our bad words don't even make a dent in his good words, isn't it wrong of God to back us to the wall and hold us to our word? These questions come up.
- 5 But if our unrighteousness brings out God's righteousness more clearly, what shall we say? That God is unjust in bringing his wrath on us? (I am using a human argument.)
- 6 The answer to such questions is no, a most emphatic No! How else would things ever get straightened out if God didn't do the straightening?
- 6 Certainly not! If that were so, how could God judge the world?
- 7 It's simply perverse to say, "If my lies serve to show off God's truth all the more gloriously, why blame me? I'm doing God a favor."
- 7 Someone might argue, "If my falsehood enhances God's truthfulness and so increases his glory, why am I still condemned as a sinner?"
- 8 Some people are actually trying to put such words in our mouths, claiming that we go around saying, "The more evil we do, the more good God does, so let's just do it!" That's pure slander, as I'm sure you'll agree.
- 8 Why not say--as we are being slanderously reported as saying and as some claim that we say--"Let us do evil that good may result"? Their condemnation is deserved.
- 9 So where does that put us? Do we Jews get a better break than the others? Not really. Basically, all of us, whether insiders or outsiders, start out in identical conditions, which is to say that we all start out as sinners. Scripture leaves no doubt about it:
- 9 What shall we conclude then? Are we any better? Not at all! We have already made the charge that Jews and Gentiles alike are all under sin.
- 10 There's nobody living right, not even one,
- 10 As it is written: "There is no one righteous, not even one;
- 11 nobody who knows the score, nobody alert for God.

11 there is no one who understands, no one who seeks God.  
12 They've all taken the wrong turn; they've all wandered down blind alleys. No one's living right; I can't find a single one.  
12 All have turned away, they have together become worthless; there is no one who does good, not even one."  
13 Their throats are gaping graves, their tongues slick as mud slides. Every word they speak is tinged with poison.  
13 Their throats are open graves; their tongues practice deceit. "The poison of vipers is on their lips."  
14 They open their mouths and pollute the air.  
14 Their mouths are full of cursing and bitterness.  
15 They race for the honor of sinner-of-the-year,  
15 Their feet are swift to shed blood;  
16 litter the land with heartbreak and ruin,  
16 ruin and misery mark their ways,  
17 Don't know the first thing about living with others.  
17 and the way of peace they do not know."  
18 They never give God the time of day.  
18 There is no fear of God before their eyes.  
19 This makes it clear, doesn't it, that whatever is written in these Scriptures is not what God says about others but to us to whom these Scriptures were addressed in the first place! And it's clear enough, isn't it, that we're sinners, every one of us, in the same sinking boat with everybody else?  
19 Now we know that whatever the law says, it says to those who are under the law, so that every mouth may be silenced and the whole world held accountable to God.  
20 Our involvement with God's revelation doesn't put us right with God. What it does is force us to face our complicity in everyone else's sin.  
20 Therefore no one will be declared righteous in his sight by observing the law; rather, through the law we become conscious of sin.  
21 But in our time something new has been added. What Moses and the prophets witnessed to all those years has happened.  
21 But now a righteousness from God, apart from law, has been made known, to which the Law and the Prophets testify.

- 22 The God-setting-things-right that we read about has become Jesus-setting-things-right for us. And not only for us, but for everyone who believes in him. For there is no difference between us and them in this.
- 22 This righteousness from God comes through faith in Jesus Christ to all who believe. There is no difference,
- 23 Since we've compiled this long and sorry record as sinners (both us and them) and proved that we are utterly incapable of living the glorious lives God wills for us,
- 23 for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,
- 24 God did it for us. Out of sheer generosity he put us in right standing with himself. A pure gift. He got us out of the mess we're in and restored us to where he always wanted us to be. And he did it by means of Jesus Christ.
- 24 and are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that came by Christ Jesus.
- 25 God sacrificed Jesus on the altar of the world to clear that world of sin. Having faith in him sets us in the clear. God decided on this course of action in full view of the public--to set the world in the clear with himself through the sacrifice of Jesus, finally taking care of the sins he had so patiently endured.
- 25 God presented him as a sacrifice of atonement, through faith in his blood. He did this to demonstrate his justice, because in his forbearance he had left the sins committed beforehand unpunished--
- 26 This is not only clear, but it's now--this is current history! God sets things right. He also makes it possible for us to live in his rightness.
- 26 he did it to demonstrate his justice at the present time, so as to be just and the one who justifies those who have faith in Jesus.
- 27 So where does that leave our proud Jewish insider claims and counterclaims? Canceled? Yes, canceled. What we've learned is this: God does not respond to what we do; we respond to what God does.
- 27 Where, then, is boasting? It is excluded. On what principle? On that of observing the law? No, but on that of faith.
- 28 We've finally figured it out. Our lives get in step with God and all others by letting him set the pace, not by proudly or anxiously trying to run the parade.

- 28 For we maintain that a man is justified by faith apart from observing the law.
- 29 And where does that leave our proud Jewish claim of having a corner on God? Also canceled. God is the God of outsider non-Jews as well as insider Jews.
- 29 Is God the God of Jews only? Is he not the God of Gentiles too? Yes, of Gentiles too,
- 30 How could it be otherwise since there is only one God? God sets right all who welcome his action and enter into it, both those who follow our religious system and those who have never heard of our religion.
- 30 since there is only one God, who will justify the circumcised by faith and the uncircumcised through that same faith.
- 31 But by shifting our focus from what we do to what God does, don't we cancel out all our careful keeping of the rules and ways God commanded? Not at all. What happens, in fact, is that by putting that entire way of life in its proper place, we confirm it.
- 31 Do we, then, nullify the law by this faith? Not at all! Rather, we uphold the law.

## **Romans 4**

MSG

NIV

- 1 So how do we fit what we know of Abraham, our first father in the faith, into this new way of looking at things?
- 1 What then shall we say that Abraham, our forefather, discovered in this matter?
- 2 If Abraham, by what he did for God, got God to approve him, he could certainly have taken credit for it. But the story we're given is a God-story, not an Abraham-story.
- 2 If, in fact, Abraham was justified by works, he had something to boast about--but not before God.
- 3 What we read in Scripture is, "Abraham entered into what God was doing for him, and that was the turning point. He trusted God to set him right instead of trying to be right on his own."

- 3 What does the Scripture say? "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness."
- 4 If you're a hard worker and do a good job, you deserve your pay; we don't call your wages a gift.
- 4 Now when a man works, his wages are not credited to him as a gift, but as an obligation.
- 5 But if you see that the job is too big for you, that it's something only God can do, and you trust him to do it--you could never do it for yourself no matter how hard and long you worked--well, that trusting-him-to-do-it is what gets you set right with God, by God. Sheer gift.
- 5 However, to the man who does not work but trusts God who justifies the wicked, his faith is credited as righteousness.
- 6 David confirms this way of looking at it, saying that the one who trusts God to do the putting-everything-right without insisting on having a say in it is one fortunate man:
- 6 David says the same thing when he speaks of the blessedness of the man to whom God credits righteousness apart from works:
- 7 Fortunate those whose crimes are carted off, whose sins are wiped clean from the slate.
- 7 Blessed are they whose transgressions are forgiven, whose sins are covered.
- 8 Fortunate the person against whom the Lord does not keep score.
- 8 Blessed is the man whose sin the Lord will never count against him."
- 9 Do you think for a minute that this blessing is only pronounced over those of us who keep our religious ways and are circumcised? Or do you think it possible that the blessing could be given to those who never even heard of our ways, who were never brought up in the disciplines of God? We all agree, don't we, that it was by embracing what God did for him that Abraham was declared fit before God?
- 9 Is this blessedness only for the circumcised, or also for the uncircumcised? We have been saying that Abraham's faith was credited to him as righteousness.
- 10 Now think: Was that declaration made before or after he was marked by the covenant rite of circumcision? That's right, before he was marked.
- 10 Under what circumstances was it credited? Was it after he was circumcised, or before? It was not after, but before!

- 11 That means that he underwent circumcision as evidence and confirmation of what God had done long before to bring him into this acceptable standing with himself, an act of God he had embraced with his whole life.
- 11 And he received the sign of circumcision, a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith while he was still uncircumcised. So then, he is the father of all who believe but have not been circumcised, in order that righteousness might be credited to them.
- 12 And it means further that Abraham is father of all people who embrace what God does for them while they are still on the "outs" with God, as yet unidentified as God's, in an "uncircumcised" condition. It is precisely these people in this condition who are called "set right by God and with God"! Abraham is also, of course, father of those who have undergone the religious rite of circumcision not just because of the ritual but because they were willing to live in the risky faith-embrace of God's action for them, the way Abraham lived long before he was marked by circumcision.
- 12 And he is also the father of the circumcised who not only are circumcised but who also walk in the footsteps of the faith that our father Abraham had before he was circumcised.
- 13 That famous promise God gave Abraham--that he and his children would possess the earth--was not given because of something Abraham did or would do. It was based on God's decision to put everything together for him, which Abraham then entered when he believed.
- 13 It was not through law that Abraham and his offspring received the promise that he would be heir of the world, but through the righteousness that comes by faith.
- 14 If those who get what God gives them only get it by doing everything they are told to do and filling out all the right forms properly signed, that eliminates personal trust completely and turns the promise into an ironclad contract! That's not a holy promise; that's a business deal.
- 14 For if those who live by law are heirs, faith has no value and the promise is worthless,
- 15 A contract drawn up by a hard-nosed lawyer and with plenty of fine print only makes sure that you will never be able to collect. But if there

is no contract in the first place, simply a promise--and God's promise at that--you can't break it.

15 because law brings wrath. And where there is no law there is no transgression.

16 This is why the fulfillment of God's promise depends entirely on trusting God and his way, and then simply embracing him and what he does. God's promise arrives as pure gift. That's the only way everyone can be sure to get in on it, those who keep the religious traditions and those who have never heard of them. For Abraham is father of us all. He is not our racial father--that's reading the story backwards. He is our faith father.

16 Therefore, the promise comes by faith, so that it may be by grace and may be guaranteed to all Abraham's offspring--not only to those who are of the law but also to those who are of the faith of Abraham. He is the father of us all.

17 We call Abraham "father" not because he got God's attention by living like a saint, but because God made something out of Abraham when he was a nobody. Isn't that what we've always read in Scripture, God saying to Abraham, "I set you up as father of many peoples"? Abraham was first named "father" and then became a father because he dared to trust God to do what only God could do: raise the dead to life, with a word make something out of nothing.

17 As it is written: "I have made you a father of many nations." He is our father in the sight of God, in whom he believed--the God who gives life to the dead and calls things that are not as though they were.

18 When everything was hopeless, Abraham believed anyway, deciding to live not on the basis of what he saw he couldn't do but on what God said he would do. And so he was made father of a multitude of peoples. God himself said to him, "You're going to have a big family, Abraham!"

18 Against all hope, Abraham in hope believed and so became the father of many nations, just as it had been said to him, "So shall your offspring be."

19 Abraham didn't focus on his own impotence and say, "It's hopeless. This hundred-year-old body could never father a child." Nor did he survey Sarah's decades of infertility and give up.

- 19 Without weakening in his faith, he faced the fact that his body was as good as dead--since he was about a hundred years old--and that Sarah's womb was also dead.
- 20 He didn't tiptoe around God's promise asking cautiously skeptical questions. He plunged into the promise and came up strong, ready for God,
- 20 Yet he did not waver through unbelief regarding the promise of God, but was strengthened in his faith and gave glory to God,
- 21 sure that God would make good on what he had said.
- 21 being fully persuaded that God had power to do what he had promised.
- 22 That's why it is said, "Abraham was declared fit before God by trusting God to set him right."
- 22 This is why "it was credited to him as righteousness."
- 23 But it's not just Abraham;
- 23 The words "it was credited to him" were written not for him alone,
- 24 it's also us! The same thing gets said about us when we embrace and believe the One who brought Jesus to life when the conditions were equally hopeless.
- 24 but also for us, to whom God will credit righteousness--for us who believe in him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead.
- 25 The sacrificed Jesus made us fit for God, set us right with God.
- 25 He was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification.

## **Romans 5**

MSG

NIV

- 1 By entering through faith into what God has always wanted to do for us--set us right with him, make us fit for him--we have it all together with God because of our Master Jesus.
- 1 Therefore, since we have been justified through faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ,
- 2 And that's not all: We throw open our doors to God and discover at the same moment that he has already thrown open his door to us. We find ourselves standing where we always hoped we might stand--out in the

- wide open spaces of God's grace and glory, standing tall and shouting our praise.
- 2 through whom we have gained access by faith into this grace in which we now stand. And we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God.
  - 3 There's more to come: We continue to shout our praise even when we're hemmed in with troubles, because we know how troubles can develop passionate patience in us,
  - 3 Not only so, but we also rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance;
  - 4 and how that patience in turn forges the tempered steel of virtue, keeping us alert for whatever God will do next.
  - 4 perseverance, character; and character, hope.
  - 5 In alert expectancy such as this, we're never left feeling shortchanged. Quite the contrary--we can't round up enough containers to hold everything God generously pours into our lives through the Holy Spirit!
  - 5 And hope does not disappoint us, because God has poured out his love into our hearts by the Holy Spirit, whom he has given us.
  - 6 Christ arrives right on time to make this happen. He didn't, and doesn't, wait for us to get ready. He presented himself for this sacrificial death when we were far too weak and rebellious to do anything to get ourselves ready. And even if we hadn't been so weak, we wouldn't have known what to do anyway.
  - 6 You see, at just the right time, when we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly.
  - 7 We can understand someone dying for a person worth dying for, and we can understand how someone good and noble could inspire us to selfless sacrifice.
  - 7 Very rarely will anyone die for a righteous man, though for a good man someone might possibly dare to die.
  - 8 But God put his love on the line for us by offering his Son in sacrificial death while we were of no use whatever to him.
  - 8 But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.
  - 9 Now that we are set right with God by means of this sacrificial death, the consummate blood sacrifice, there is no longer a question of being at odds with God in any way.

- 9 Since we have now been justified by his blood, how much more shall we be saved from God's wrath through him!
- 10 If, when we were at our worst, we were put on friendly terms with God by the sacrificial death of his Son, now that we're at our best, just think of how our lives will expand and deepen by means of his resurrection life!
- 10 For if, when we were God's enemies, we were reconciled to him through the death of his Son, how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through his life!
- 11 Now that we have actually received this amazing friendship with God, we are no longer content to simply say it in plodding prose. We sing and shout our praises to God through Jesus, the Messiah!
- 11 Not only is this so, but we also rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received reconciliation.
- 12 You know the story of how Adam landed us in the dilemma we're in--first sin, then death, and no one exempt from either sin or death.
- 12 Therefore, just as sin entered the world through one man, and death through sin, and in this way death came to all men, because all sinned--
- 13 That sin disturbed relations with God in everything and everyone, but the extent of the disturbance was not clear until God spelled it out in detail to Moses. So death, this huge abyss separating us from God, dominated the landscape from Adam to Moses.
- 13 for before the law was given, sin was in the world. But sin is not taken into account when there is no law.
- 14 Even those who didn't sin precisely as Adam did by disobeying a specific command of God still had to experience this termination of life, this separation from God. But Adam, who got us into this, also points ahead to the One who will get us out of it.
- 14 Nevertheless, death reigned from the time of Adam to the time of Moses, even over those who did not sin by breaking a command, as did Adam, who was a pattern of the one to come.
- 15 Yet the rescuing gift is not exactly parallel to the death-dealing sin. If one man's sin put crowds of people at the dead-end abyss of separation from God, just think what God's gift poured through one man, Jesus Christ, will do!

- 15 But the gift is not like the trespass. For if the many died by the trespass of the one man, how much more did God's grace and the gift that came by the grace of the one man, Jesus Christ, overflow to the many!
- 16 There's no comparison between that death-dealing sin and this generous, life-giving gift. The verdict on that one sin was the death sentence; the verdict on the many sins that followed was this wonderful life sentence.
- 16 Again, the gift of God is not like the result of the one man's sin: The judgment followed one sin and brought condemnation, but the gift followed many trespasses and brought justification.
- 17 If death got the upper hand through one man's wrongdoing, can you imagine the breathtaking recovery life makes, sovereign life, in those who grasp with both hands this wildly extravagant life-gift, this grand setting-everything-right, that the one man Jesus Christ provides?
- 17 For if, by the trespass of the one man, death reigned through that one man, how much more will those who receive God's abundant provision of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man, Jesus Christ.
- 18 Here it is in a nutshell: Just as one person did it wrong and got us in all this trouble with sin and death, another person did it right and got us out of it. But more than just getting us out of trouble, he got us into life!
- 18 Consequently, just as the result of one trespass was condemnation for all men, so also the result of one act of righteousness was justification that brings life for all men.
- 19 One man said no to God and put many people in the wrong; one man said yes to God and put many in the right.
- 19 For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous.
- 20 All that passing laws against sin did was produce more lawbreakers. But sin didn't, and doesn't, have a chance in competition with the aggressive forgiveness we call grace. When it's sin versus grace, grace wins hands down.
- 20 The law was added so that the trespass might increase. But where sin increased, grace increased all the more,
- 21 All sin can do is threaten us with death, and that's the end of it. Grace, because God is putting everything together again through the Messiah,

invites us into life--a life that goes on and on and on, world without end.  
21 so that, just as sin reigned in death, so also grace might reign through righteousness to bring eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

## **Romans 6**

MSG

NIV

- 1 So what do we do? Keep on sinning so God can keep on forgiving?
- 1 What shall we say, then? Shall we go on sinning so that grace may increase?
- 2 I should hope not! If we've left the country where sin is sovereign, how can we still live in our old house there?
- 2 By no means! We died to sin; how can we live in it any longer?
- 3 Or didn't you realize we packed up and left there for good? That is what happened in baptism. When we went under the water, we left the old country of sin behind; when we came up out of the water, we entered into the new country of grace--a new life in a new land! That's what baptism into the life of Jesus means.
- 3 Or don't you know that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?
- 4 When we are lowered into the water, it is like the burial of Jesus; when we are raised up out of the water, it is like the resurrection of Jesus.
- 4 We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life.
- 5 Each of us is raised into a light-filled world by our Father so that we can see where we're going in our new grace-sovereign country.
- 5 If we have been united with him like this in his death, we will certainly also be united with him in his resurrection.
- 6 Could it be any clearer? Our old way of life was nailed to the Cross with Christ, a decisive end to that sin-miserable life--no longer at sin's every beck and call! What we believe is this:
- 6 For we know that our old self was crucified with him so that the body of sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves to sin--
- 7 (SEE 6:6)

- 7 because anyone who has died has been freed from sin.
- 8 If we get included in Christ's sin-conquering death, we also get included in his life-saving resurrection.
- 8 Now if we died with Christ, we believe that we will also live with him.
- 9 We know that when Jesus was raised from the dead it was a signal of the end of death-as-the-end. Never again will death have the last word.
- 9 For we know that since Christ was raised from the dead, he cannot die again; death no longer has mastery over him.
- 10 When Jesus died, he took sin down with him, but alive he brings God down to us.
- 10 The death he died, he died to sin once for all; but the life he lives, he lives to God.
- 11 From now on, think of it this way: Sin speaks a dead language that means nothing to you; God speaks your mother tongue, and you hang on every word. You are dead to sin and alive to God. That's what Jesus did.
- 11 In the same way, count yourselves dead to sin but alive to God in Christ Jesus.
- 12 That means you must not give sin a vote in the way you conduct your lives. Don't give it the time of day.
- 12 Therefore do not let sin reign in your mortal body so that you obey its evil desires.
- 13 Don't even run little errands that are connected with that old way of life. Throw yourselves wholeheartedly and full-time--remember, you've been raised from the dead!--into God's way of doing things.
- 13 Do not offer the parts of your body to sin, as instruments of wickedness, but rather offer yourselves to God, as those who have been brought from death to life; and offer the parts of your body to him as instruments of righteousness.
- 14 Sin can't tell you how to live. After all, you're not living under that old tyranny any longer. You're living in the freedom of God.
- 14 For sin shall not be your master, because you are not under law, but under grace.
- 15 So, since we're out from under the old tyranny, does that mean we can live any old way we want? Since we're free in the freedom of God, can we do anything that comes to mind?

- 15 What then? Shall we sin because we are not under law but under grace?  
By no means!
- 16 Hardly. You know well enough from your own experience that there are some acts of so-called freedom that destroy freedom. Offer yourselves to sin, for instance, and it's your last free act. But offer yourselves to the ways of God and the freedom never quits. All your lives you've let sin tell you what to do.
- 16 Don't you know that when you offer yourselves to someone to obey him as slaves, you are slaves to the one whom you obey--whether you are slaves to sin, which leads to death, or to obedience, which leads to righteousness?
- 17 But thank God you've started listening to a new master,
- 17 But thanks be to God that, though you used to be slaves to sin, you wholeheartedly obeyed the form of teaching to which you were entrusted.
- 18 one whose commands set you free to live openly in his freedom!
- 18 You have been set free from sin and have become slaves to righteousness.
- 19 I'm using this freedom language because it's easy to picture. You can readily recall, can't you, how at one time the more you did just what you felt like doing--not caring about others, not caring about God--the worse your life became and the less freedom you had? And how much different is it now as you live in God's freedom, your lives healed and expansive in holiness?
- 19 I put this in human terms because you are weak in your natural selves. Just as you used to offer the parts of your body in slavery to impurity and to ever-increasing wickedness, so now offer them in slavery to righteousness leading to holiness.
- 20 As long as you did what you felt like doing, ignoring God, you didn't have to bother with right thinking or right living, or right anything for that matter.
- 20 When you were slaves to sin, you were free from the control of righteousness.
- 21 But do you call that a free life? What did you get out of it? Nothing you're proud of now. Where did it get you? A dead end.

- 21 What benefit did you reap at that time from the things you are now ashamed of? Those things result in death!
- 22 But now that you've found you don't have to listen to sin tell you what to do, and have discovered the delight of listening to God telling you, what a surprise! A whole, healed, put-together life right now, with more and more of life on the way!
- 22 But now that you have been set free from sin and have become slaves to God, the benefit you reap leads to holiness, and the result is eternal life.
- 23 Work hard for sin your whole life and your pension is death. But God's gift is real life, eternal life, delivered by Jesus, our Master.
- 23 For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

## **Romans 7**

MSG

NIV

- 1 You shouldn't have any trouble understanding this, friends, for you know all the ins and outs of the law--how it works and how its power touches only the living.
- 1 Do you not know, brothers--for I am speaking to men who know the law--that the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives?
- 2 For instance, a wife is legally tied to her husband while he lives, but if he dies, she's free.
- 2 For example, by law a married woman is bound to her husband as long as he is alive, but if her husband dies, she is released from the law of marriage.
- 3 If she lives with another man while her husband is living, she's obviously an adulteress. But if he dies, she is quite free to marry another man in good conscience, with no one's disapproval.
- 3 So then, if she marries another man while her husband is still alive, she is called an adulteress. But if her husband dies, she is released from that law and is not an adulteress, even though she marries another man.
- 4 So, my friends, this is something like what has taken place with you. When Christ died he took that entire rule-dominated way of life down

with him and left it in the tomb, leaving you free to "marry" a resurrection life and bear "offspring" of faith for God.

- 4 So, my brothers, you also died to the law through the body of Christ, that you might belong to another, to him who was raised from the dead, in order that we might bear fruit to God.
- 5 For as long as we lived that old way of life, doing whatever we felt we could get away with, sin was calling most of the shots as the old law code hemmed us in. And this made us all the more rebellious. In the end, all we had to show for it was miscarriages and stillbirths.
- 5 For when we were controlled by the sinful nature, the sinful passions aroused by the law were at work in our bodies, so that we bore fruit for death.
- 6 But now that we're no longer shackled to that domineering mate of sin, and out from under all those oppressive regulations and fine print, we're free to live a new life in the freedom of God.
- 6 But now, by dying to what once bound us, we have been released from the law so that we serve in the new way of the Spirit, and not in the old way of the written code.
- 7 But I can hear you say, "If the law code was as bad as all that, it's no better than sin itself." That's certainly not true. The law code had a perfectly legitimate function. Without its clear guidelines for right and wrong, moral behavior would be mostly guesswork. Apart from the succinct, surgical command, "You shall not covet," I could have dressed covetousness up to look like a virtue and ruined my life with it.
- 7 What shall we say, then? Is the law sin? Certainly not! Indeed I would not have known what sin was except through the law. For I would not have known what coveting really was if the law had not said, "Do not covet."
- 8 Don't you remember how it was? I do, perfectly well. The law code started out as an excellent piece of work. What happened, though, was that sin found a way to pervert the command into a temptation, making a piece of "forbidden fruit" out of it. The law code, instead of being used to guide me, was used to seduce me. Without all the paraphernalia of the law code, sin looked pretty dull and lifeless,
- 8 But sin, seizing the opportunity afforded by the commandment, produced in me every kind of covetous desire. For apart from law, sin is dead.

- 9 and I went along without paying much attention to it. But once sin got its hands on the law code and decked itself out in all that finery, I was fooled, and fell for it.
- 9 Once I was alive apart from law; but when the commandment came, sin sprang to life and I died.
- 10 The very command that was supposed to guide me into life was cleverly used to trip me up, throwing me headlong.
- 10 I found that the very commandment that was intended to bring life actually brought death.
- 11 So sin was plenty alive, and I was stone dead.
- 11 For sin, seizing the opportunity afforded by the commandment, deceived me, and through the commandment put me to death.
- 12 But the law code itself is God's good and common sense, each command sane and holy counsel.
- 12 So then, the law is holy, and the commandment is holy, righteous and good.
- 13 I can already hear your next question: "Does that mean I can't even trust what is good [that is, the law]? Is good just as dangerous as evil?" No again! Sin simply did what sin is so famous for doing: using the good as a cover to tempt me to do what would finally destroy me. By hiding within God's good commandment, sin did far more mischief than it could ever have accomplished on its own.
- 13 Did that which is good, then, become death to me? By no means! But in order that sin might be recognized as sin, it produced death in me through what was good, so that through the commandment sin might become utterly sinful.
- 14 I can anticipate the response that is coming: "I know that all God's commands are spiritual, but I'm not. Isn't this also your experience?" Yes. I'm full of myself--after all, I've spent a long time in sin's prison.
- 14 We know that the law is spiritual; but I am unspiritual, sold as a slave to sin.
- 15 What I don't understand about myself is that I decide one way, but then I act another, doing things I absolutely despise.
- 15 I do not understand what I do. For what I want to do I do not do, but what I hate I do.

- 16 So if I can't be trusted to figure out what is best for myself and then do it, it becomes obvious that God's command is necessary.
- 16 And if I do what I do not want to do, I agree that the law is good.
- 17 But I need something more! For if I know the law but still can't keep it, and if the power of sin within me keeps sabotaging my best intentions, I obviously need help!
- 17 As it is, it is no longer I myself who do it, but it is sin living in me.
- 18 I realize that I don't have what it takes. I can will it, but I can't do it.
- 18 I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my sinful nature. For I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out.
- 19 I decide to do good, but I don't really do it; I decide not to do bad, but then I do it anyway.
- 19 For what I do is not the good I want to do; no, the evil I do not want to do--this I keep on doing.
- 20 My decisions, such as they are, don't result in actions. Something has gone wrong deep within me and gets the better of me every time.
- 20 Now if I do what I do not want to do, it is no longer I who do it, but it is sin living in me that does it.
- 21 It happens so regularly that it's predictable. The moment I decide to do good, sin is there to trip me up.
- 21 So I find this law at work: When I want to do good, evil is right there with me.
- 22 I truly delight in God's commands,
- 22 For in my inner being I delight in God's law;
- 23 but it's pretty obvious that not all of me joins in that delight. Parts of me covertly rebel, and just when I least expect it, they take charge.
- 23 but I see another law at work in the members of my body, waging war against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin at work within my members.
- 24 I've tried everything and nothing helps. I'm at the end of my rope. Is there no one who can do anything for me? Isn't that the real question?
- 24 What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death?
- 25 The answer, thank God, is that Jesus Christ can and does. He acted to set things right in this life of contradictions where I want to serve God

with all my heart and mind, but am pulled by the influence of sin to do something totally different.

25 Thanks be to God--through Jesus Christ our Lord! So then, I myself in my mind am a slave to God's law, but in the sinful nature a slave to the law of sin.

## **Romans 8**

MSG

NIV

- 1 With the arrival of Jesus, the Messiah, that fateful dilemma is resolved. Those who enter into Christ's being-here-for-us no longer have to live under a continuous, low-lying black cloud.
- 1 Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus,
- 2 A new power is in operation. The Spirit of life in Christ, like a strong wind, has magnificently cleared the air, freeing you from a fated lifetime of brutal tyranny at the hands of sin and death.
- 2 because through Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit of life set me free from the law of sin and death.
- 3 God went for the jugular when he sent his own Son. He didn't deal with the problem as something remote and unimportant. In his Son, Jesus, he personally took on the human condition, entered the disordered mess of struggling humanity in order to set it right once and for all. The law code, weakened as it always was by fractured human nature, could never have done that. The law always ended up being used as a Band-Aid on sin instead of a deep healing of it.
- 3 For what the law was powerless to do in that it was weakened by the sinful nature, God did by sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful man to be a sin offering. And so he condemned sin in sinful man,
- 4 And now what the law code asked for but we couldn't deliver is accomplished as we, instead of redoubling our own efforts, simply embrace what the Spirit is doing in us.
- 4 in order that the righteous requirements of the law might be fully met in us, who do not live according to the sinful nature but according to the Spirit.

- 5 Those who think they can do it on their own end up obsessed with measuring their own moral muscle but never get around to exercising it in real life. Those who trust God's action in them find that God's Spirit is in them--living and breathing God!
- 5 Those who live according to the sinful nature have their minds set on what that nature desires; but those who live in accordance with the Spirit have their minds set on what the Spirit desires.
- 6 Obsession with self in these matters is a dead end; attention to God leads us out into the open, into a spacious, free life.
- 6 The mind of sinful man is death, but the mind controlled by the Spirit is life and peace;
- 7 Focusing on the self is the opposite of focusing on God. Anyone completely absorbed in self ignores God, ends up thinking more about self than God. That person ignores who God is and what he is doing.
- 7 the sinful mind is hostile to God. It does not submit to God's law, nor can it do so.
- 8 And God isn't pleased at being ignored.
- 8 Those controlled by the sinful nature cannot please God.
- 9 But if God himself has taken up residence in your life, you can hardly be thinking more of yourself than of him. Anyone, of course, who has not welcomed this invisible but clearly present God, the Spirit of Christ, won't know what we're talking about.
- 9 You, however, are controlled not by the sinful nature but by the Spirit, if the Spirit of God lives in you. And if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he does not belong to Christ.
- 10 But for you who welcome him, in whom he dwells--even though you still experience all the limitations of sin--you yourself experience life on God's terms.
- 10 But if Christ is in you, your body is dead because of sin, yet your spirit is alive because of righteousness.
- 11 It stands to reason, doesn't it, that if the alive-and-present God who raised Jesus from the dead moves into your life, he'll do the same thing in you that he did in Jesus, bringing you alive to himself? When God lives and breathes in you (and he does, as surely as he did in Jesus), you are delivered from that dead life. With his Spirit living in you, your body will be as alive as Christ's!

- 11 And if the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead is living in you, he who raised Christ from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through his Spirit, who lives in you.
- 12 So don't you see that we don't owe this old do-it-yourself life one red cent.
- 12 Therefore, brothers, we have an obligation--but it is not to the sinful nature, to live according to it.
- 13 There's nothing in it for us, nothing at all. The best thing to do is give it a decent burial and get on with your new life.
- 13 For if you live according to the sinful nature, you will die; but if by the Spirit you put to death the misdeeds of the body, you will live,
- 14 God's Spirit beckons. There are things to do and places to go!
- 14 because those who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God.
- 15 This resurrection life you received from God is not a timid, grave-tending life. It's adventurously expectant, greeting God with a childlike "What's next, Papa?"
- 15 For you did not receive a spirit that makes you a slave again to fear, but you received the Spirit of sonship. And by him we cry, "Abba, Father."
- 16 God's Spirit touches our spirits and confirms who we really are. We know who he is, and we know who we are: Father and children.
- 16 The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God's children.
- 17 And we know we are going to get what's coming to us--an unbelievable inheritance! We go through exactly what Christ goes through. If we go through the hard times with him, then we're certainly going to go through the good times with him!
- 17 Now if we are children, then we are heirs--heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ, if indeed we share in his sufferings in order that we may also share in his glory.
- 18 That's why I don't think there's any comparison between the present hard times and the coming good times.
- 18 I consider that our present sufferings are not worth comparing with the glory that will be revealed in us.
- 19 The created world itself can hardly wait for what's coming next.
- 19 The creation waits in eager expectation for the sons of God to be revealed.
- 20 Everything in creation is being more or less held back. God reins it in

20 For the creation was subjected to frustration, not by its own choice, but by the will of the one who subjected it, in hope

21 until both creation and all the creatures are ready and can be released at the same moment into the glorious times ahead. Meanwhile, the joyful anticipation deepens.

21 that the creation itself will be liberated from its bondage to decay and brought into the glorious freedom of the children of God.

22 All around us we observe a pregnant creation. The difficult times of pain throughout the world are simply birth pangs. But it's not only around us; it's within us. The Spirit of God is arousing us within. We're also feeling the birth pangs.

22 We know that the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time.

23 These sterile and barren bodies of ours are yearning for full deliverance.

23 Not only so, but we ourselves, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we wait eagerly for our adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies.

24 That is why waiting does not diminish us, any more than waiting diminishes a pregnant mother. We are enlarged in the waiting. We, of course, don't see what is enlarging us.

24 For in this hope we were saved. But hope that is seen is no hope at all. Who hopes for what he already has?

25 But the longer we wait, the larger we become, and the more joyful our expectancy.

25 But if we hope for what we do not yet have, we wait for it patiently.

26 Meanwhile, the moment we get tired in the waiting, God's Spirit is right alongside helping us along. If we don't know how or what to pray, it doesn't matter. He does our praying in and for us, making prayer out of our wordless sighs, our aching groans.

26 In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray for, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groans that words cannot express.

27 He knows us far better than we know ourselves, knows our pregnant condition, and keeps us present before God.

27 And he who searches our hearts knows the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints in accordance with God's will.

- 28 That's why we can be so sure that every detail in our lives of love for God is worked into something good.
- 28 And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose.
- 29 God knew what he was doing from the very beginning. He decided from the outset to shape the lives of those who love him along the same lines as the life of his Son. The Son stands first in the line of humanity he restored. We see the original and intended shape of our lives there in him.
- 29 For those God foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the likeness of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brothers.
- 30 After God made that decision of what his children should be like, he followed it up by calling people by name. After he called them by name, he set them on a solid basis with himself. And then, after getting them established, he stayed with them to the end, gloriously completing what he had begun.
- 30 And those he predestined, he also called; those he called, he also justified; those he justified, he also glorified.
- 31 So, what do you think? With God on our side like this, how can we lose?
- 31 What, then, shall we say in response to this? If God is for us, who can be against us?
- 32 If God didn't hesitate to put everything on the line for us, embracing our condition and exposing himself to the worst by sending his own Son, is there anything else he wouldn't gladly and freely do for us?
- 32 He who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all--how will he not also, along with him, graciously give us all things?
- 33 And who would dare tangle with God by messing with one of God's chosen?
- 33 Who will bring any charge against those whom God has chosen? It is God who justifies.
- 34 Who would dare even to point a finger? The One who died for us--who was raised to life for us!--is in the presence of God at this very moment sticking up for us.
- 34 Who is he that condemns? Christ Jesus, who died--more than that, who was raised to life--is at the right hand of God and is also interceding for

us.

- 35 Do you think anyone is going to be able to drive a wedge between us and Christ's love for us? There is no way! Not trouble, not hard times, not hatred, not hunger, not homelessness, not bullying threats, not backstabbing, not even the worst sins listed in Scripture:
- 35 Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or hardship or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword?
- 36 They kill us in cold blood because they hate you. We're sitting ducks; they pick us off one by one.
- 36 As it is written: "For your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered."
- 37 None of this fazes us because Jesus loves us.
- 37 No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us.
- 38 I'm absolutely convinced that nothing--nothing living or dead, angelic or demonic, today or tomorrow,
- 38 For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers,
- 39 high or low, thinkable or unthinkable--absolutely nothing can get between us and God's love because of the way that Jesus our Master has embraced us.
- 39 neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

## **Romans 9**

MSG

NIV

- 1 At the same time, you need to know that I carry with me at all times a huge sorrow.
- 1 I speak the truth in Christ--I am not lying, my conscience confirms it in the Holy Spirit--
- 2 It's an enormous pain deep within me, and I'm never free of it. I'm not exaggerating--Christ and the Holy Spirit are my witnesses. It's the Israelites . . .
- 2 I have great sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart.

3 If there were any way I could be cursed by the Messiah so they could be blessed by him, I'd do it in a minute. They're my family.

3 For I could wish that I myself were cursed and cut off from Christ for the sake of my brothers, those of my own race,

4 I grew up with them. They had everything going for them--family, glory, covenants, revelation, worship, promises,

4 the people of Israel. Theirs is the adoption as sons; theirs the divine glory, the covenants, the receiving of the law, the temple worship and the promises.

5 to say nothing of being the race that produced the Messiah, the Christ, who is God over everything, always. Oh, yes!

5 Theirs are the patriarchs, and from them is traced the human ancestry of Christ, who is God over all, forever praised! Amen.

6 Don't suppose for a moment, though, that God's Word has malfunctioned in some way or other. The problem goes back a long way. From the outset, not all Israelites of the flesh were Israelites of the spirit.

6 It is not as though God's word had failed. For not all who are descended from Israel are Israel.

7 It wasn't Abraham's sperm that gave identity here, but God's promise. Remember how it was put: "Your family will be defined by Isaac"?

7 Nor because they are his descendants are they all Abraham's children. On the contrary, "It is through Isaac that your offspring will be reckoned."

8 That means that Israelite identity was never racially determined by sexual transmission, but it was God-determined by promise.

8 In other words, it is not the natural children who are God's children, but it is the children of the promise who are regarded as Abraham's offspring.

9 Remember that promise, "When I come back next year at this time, Sarah will have a son"?

9 For this was how the promise was stated: "At the appointed time I will return, and Sarah will have a son."

10 And that's not the only time. To Rebecca, also, a promise was made that took priority over genetics. When she became pregnant by our one-of-a-kind ancestor, Isaac,

10 Not only that, but Rebekah's children had one and the same father, our father Isaac.

- 11 and her babies were still innocent in the womb--incapable of good or bad--she received a special assurance from God. What God did in this case made it perfectly plain that his purpose is not a hit-or-miss thing dependent on what we do or don't do, but a sure thing determined by his decision, flowing steadily from his initiative.
- 11 Yet, before the twins were born or had done anything good or bad--in order that God's purpose in election might stand:
- 12 God told Rebecca, "The firstborn of your twins will take second place."
- 12 not by works but by him who calls--she was told, "The older will serve the younger."
- 13 Later that was turned into a stark epigram: "I loved Jacob; I hated Esau."
- 13 Just as it is written: "Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated."
- 14 Is that grounds for complaining that God is unfair? Not so fast, please.
- 14 What then shall we say? Is God unjust? Not at all!
- 15 God told Moses, "I'm in charge of mercy. I'm in charge of compassion."
- 15 For he says to Moses, "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion."
- 16 Compassion doesn't originate in our bleeding hearts or moral sweat, but in God's mercy.
- 16 It does not, therefore, depend on man's desire or effort, but on God's mercy.
- 17 The same point was made when God said to Pharaoh, "I picked you as a bit player in this drama of my salvation power."
- 17 For the Scripture says to Pharaoh: "I raised you up for this very purpose, that I might display my power in you and that my name might be proclaimed in all the earth."
- 18 All we're saying is that God has the first word, initiating the action in which we play our part for good or ill.
- 18 Therefore God has mercy on whom he wants to have mercy, and he hardens whom he wants to harden.
- 19 Are you going to object, "So how can God blame us for anything since he's in charge of everything? If the big decisions are already made, what say do we have in it?"
- 19 One of you will say to me: "Then why does God still blame us? For who resists his will?"

- 20 Who in the world do you think you are to second-guess God? Do you for one moment suppose any of us knows enough to call God into question? Clay doesn't talk back to the fingers that mold it, saying, "Why did you shape me like this?"
- 20 But who are you, O man, to talk back to God? "Shall what is formed say to him who formed it, 'Why did you make me like this?' "
- 21 Isn't it obvious that a potter has a perfect right to shape one lump of clay into a vase for holding flowers and another into a pot for cooking beans?
- 21 Does not the potter have the right to make out of the same lump of clay some pottery for noble purposes and some for common use?
- 22 If God needs one style of pottery especially designed to show his angry displeasure
- 22 What if God, choosing to show his wrath and make his power known, bore with great patience the objects of his wrath--prepared for destruction?
- 23 and another style carefully crafted to show his glorious goodness, isn't that all right?
- 23 What if he did this to make the riches of his glory known to the objects of his mercy, whom he prepared in advance for glory--
- 24 Either or both happens to Jews, but it also happens to the other people.
- 24 even us, whom he also called, not only from the Jews but also from the Gentiles?
- 25 Hosea put it well: I'll call nobodies and make them somebodies; I'll call the unloved and make them beloved.
- 25 As he says in Hosea: "I will call them 'my people' who are not my people; and I will call her 'my loved one' who is not my loved one,"
- 26 In the place where they yelled out, "You're nobody!" they're calling you "God's living children."
- 26 and, "It will happen that in the very place where it was said to them, 'You are not my people,' they will be called 'sons of the living God.' "
- 27 Isaiah maintained this same emphasis: If each grain of sand on the seashore were numbered and the sum labeled "chosen of God," They'd be numbers still, not names; salvation comes by personal selection.
- 27 Isaiah cries out concerning Israel: "Though the number of the Israelites be like the sand by the sea, only the remnant will be saved.
- 28 God doesn't count us; he calls us by name. Arithmetic is not his focus.

- 28 For the Lord will carry out his sentence on earth with speed and finality."
- 29 Isaiah had looked ahead and spoken the truth: If our powerful God had not provided us a legacy of living children, We would have ended up like ghost towns, like Sodom and Gomorrah.
- 29 It is just as Isaiah said previously: "Unless the Lord Almighty had left us descendants, we would have become like Sodom, we would have been like Gomorrah."
- 30 How can we sum this up? All those people who didn't seem interested in what God was doing actually embraced what God was doing as he straightened out their lives.
- 30 What then shall we say? That the Gentiles, who did not pursue righteousness, have obtained it, a righteousness that is by faith;
- 31 And Israel, who seemed so interested in reading and talking about what God was doing, missed it.
- 31 but Israel, who pursued a law of righteousness, has not attained it.
- 32 How could they miss it? Because instead of trusting God, they took over. They were absorbed in what they themselves were doing. They were so absorbed in their "God projects" that they didn't notice God right in front of them, like a huge rock in the middle of the road. And so they stumbled into him and went sprawling.
- 32 Why not? Because they pursued it not by faith but as if it were by works. They stumbled over the "stumbling stone."
- 33 Isaiah (again!) gives us the metaphor for pulling this together: Careful! I've put a huge stone on the road to Mount Zion, a stone you can't get around. But the stone is me! If you're looking for me, you'll find me on the way, not in the way.
- 33 As it is written: "See, I lay in Zion a stone that causes men to stumble and a rock that makes them fall, and the one who trusts in him will never be put to shame."

## **Romans 10**

MSG

NIV

- 1 Believe me, friends, all I want for Israel is what's best for Israel: salvation, nothing less. I want it with all my heart and pray to God for it all the time.
- 1 Brothers, my heart's desire and prayer to God for the Israelites is that they may be saved.
- 2 I readily admit that the Jews are impressively energetic regarding God--but they are doing everything exactly backwards.
- 2 For I can testify about them that they are zealous for God, but their zeal is not based on knowledge.
- 3 They don't seem to realize that this comprehensive setting-things-right that is salvation is God's business, and a most flourishing business it is. Right across the street they set up their own salvation shops and noisily hawk their wares. After all these years of refusing to really deal with God on his terms, insisting instead on making their own deals, they have nothing to show for it.
- 3 Since they did not know the righteousness that comes from God and sought to establish their own, they did not submit to God's righteousness.
- 4 The earlier revelation was intended simply to get us ready for the Messiah, who then puts everything right for those who trust him to do it.
- 4 Christ is the end of the law so that there may be righteousness for everyone who believes.
- 5 Moses wrote that anyone who insists on using the law code to live right before God soon discovers it's not so easy--every detail of life regulated by fine print!
- 5 Moses describes in this way the righteousness that is by the law: "The man who does these things will live by them."
- 6 But trusting God to shape the right living in us is a different story--no precarious climb up to heaven to recruit the Messiah,
- 6 But the righteousness that is by faith says: "Do not say in your heart, 'Who will ascend into heaven?' " (that is, to bring Christ down)
- 7 no dangerous descent into hell to rescue the Messiah.
- 7 or 'Who will descend into the deep?' (that is, to bring Christ up from the dead).
- 8 So what exactly was Moses saying? The word that saves is right here, as near as the tongue in your mouth, as close as the heart in your chest. It's

- the word of faith that welcomes God to go to work and set things right for us. This is the core of our preaching.
- 8 But what does it say? "The word is near you; it is in your mouth and in your heart," that is, the word of faith we are proclaiming:
- 9 Say the welcoming word to God--"Jesus is my Master"--embracing, body and soul, God's work of doing in us what he did in raising Jesus from the dead. That's it. You're not "doing" anything; you're simply calling out to God, trusting him to do it for you. That's salvation.
- 9 That if you confess with your mouth, "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.
- 10 With your whole being you embrace God setting things right, and then you say it, right out loud: "God has set everything right between him and me!"
- 10 For it is with your heart that you believe and are justified, and it is with your mouth that you confess and are saved.
- 11 Scripture reassures us, "No one who trusts God like this--heart and soul--will ever regret it."
- 11 As the Scripture says, "Anyone who trusts in him will never be put to shame."
- 12 It's exactly the same no matter what a person's religious background may be: the same God for all of us, acting the same incredibly generous way to everyone who calls out for help.
- 12 For there is no difference between Jew and Gentile--the same Lord is Lord of all and richly blesses all who call on him,
- 13 "Everyone who calls, 'Help, God!' gets help."
- 13 for, "Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved."
- 14 But how can people call for help if they don't know who to trust? And how can they know who to trust if they haven't heard of the One who can be trusted? And how can they hear if nobody tells them?
- 14 How, then, can they call on the one they have not believed in? And how can they believe in the one of whom they have not heard? And how can they hear without someone preaching to them?
- 15 And how is anyone going to tell them, unless someone is sent to do it? That's why Scripture exclaims, A sight to take your breath away! Grand processions of people telling all the good things of God!

- 15 And how can they preach unless they are sent? As it is written, "How beautiful are the feet of those who bring good news!"
- 16 But not everybody is ready for this, ready to see and hear and act. Isaiah asked what we all ask at one time or another: "Does anyone care, God? Is anyone listening and believing a word of it?"
- 16 But not all the Israelites accepted the good news. For Isaiah says, "Lord, who has believed our message?"
- 17 The point is, Before you trust, you have to listen. But unless Christ's Word is preached, there's nothing to listen to.
- 17 Consequently, faith comes from hearing the message, and the message is heard through the word of Christ.
- 18 But haven't there been plenty of opportunities for Israel to listen and understand what's going on? Plenty, I'd say. Preachers' voices have gone 'round the world, Their message to earth's seven seas.
- 18 But I ask: Did they not hear? Of course they did: "Their voice has gone out into all the earth, their words to the ends of the world."
- 19 So the big question is, Why didn't Israel understand that she had no corner on this message? Moses had it right when he predicted, When you see God reach out to those you consider your inferiors--outsiders!--you'll become insanely jealous. When you see God reach out to people you think are religiously stupid, you'll throw temper tantrums.
- 19 Again I ask: Did Israel not understand? First, Moses says, "I will make you envious by those who are not a nation; I will make you angry by a nation that has no understanding."
- 20 Isaiah dared to speak out these words of God: People found and welcomed me who never so much as looked for me. And I found and welcomed people who had never even asked about me.
- 20 And Isaiah boldly says, "I was found by those who did not seek me; I revealed myself to those who did not ask for me."
- 21 Then he capped it with a damning indictment: Day after day after day, I beckoned Israel with open arms, And got nothing for my trouble but cold shoulders and icy stares.
- 21 But concerning Israel he says, "All day long I have held out my hands to a disobedient and obstinate people."

# Romans 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 Does this mean, then, that God is so fed up with Israel that he'll have nothing more to do with them? Hardly. Remember that I, the one writing these things, am an Israelite, a descendant of Abraham out of the tribe of Benjamin. You can't get much more Semitic than that!
- 1 I ask then: Did God reject his people? By no means! I am an Israelite myself, a descendant of Abraham, from the tribe of Benjamin.
- 2 So we're not talking about repudiation. God has been too long involved with Israel, has too much invested, to simply wash his hands of them. Do you remember that time Elijah was agonizing over this same Israel and cried out in prayer?
- 2 God did not reject his people, whom he foreknew. Don't you know what the Scripture says in the passage about Elijah--how he appealed to God against Israel:
- 3 God, they murdered your prophets, They trashed your altars; I'm the only one left and now they're after me!
- 3 Lord, they have killed your prophets and torn down your altars; I am the only one left, and they are trying to kill me ?
- 4 And do you remember God's answer? I still have seven thousand who haven't quit, Seven thousand who are loyal to the finish.
- 4 And what was God's answer to him? "I have reserved for myself seven thousand who have not bowed the knee to Baal."
- 5 It's the same today. There's a fiercely loyal minority still--not many, perhaps, but probably more than you think.
- 5 So too, at the present time there is a remnant chosen by grace.
- 6 They're holding on, not because of what they think they're going to get out of it, but because they're convinced of God's grace and purpose in choosing them. If they were only thinking of their own immediate self-interest, they would have left long ago.
- 6 And if by grace, then it is no longer by works; if it were, grace would no longer be grace.
- 7 And then what happened? Well, when Israel tried to be right with God on her own, pursuing her own self-interest, she didn't succeed. The chosen

ones of God were those who let God pursue his interest in them, and as a result received his stamp of legitimacy. The "self-interest Israel" became thick-skinned toward God.

- 7 What then? What Israel sought so earnestly it did not obtain, but the elect did. The others were hardened,
- 8 Moses and Isaiah both commented on this: Fed up with their quarrelsome, self-centered ways, God blurred their eyes and dulled their ears, Shut them in on themselves in a hall of mirrors, and they're there to this day.
- 8 as it is written: "God gave them a spirit of stupor, eyes so that they could not see and ears so that they could not hear, to this very day."
- 9 David was upset about the same thing: I hope they get sick eating self-serving meals, break a leg walking their self-serving ways.
- 9 And David says: "May their table become a snare and a trap, a stumbling block and a retribution for them.
- 10 I hope they go blind staring in their mirrors, get ulcers from playing at god.
- 10 May their eyes be darkened so they cannot see, and their backs be bent forever."
- 11 The next question is, "Are they down for the count? Are they out of this for good?" And the answer is a clear-cut no. Ironically when they walked out, they left the door open and the outsiders walked in. But the next thing you know, the Jews were starting to wonder if perhaps they had walked out on a good thing.
- 11 Again I ask: Did they stumble so as to fall beyond recovery? Not at all! Rather, because of their transgression, salvation has come to the Gentiles to make Israel envious.
- 12 Now, if their leaving triggered this worldwide coming of non-Jewish outsiders to God's kingdom, just imagine the effect of their coming back! What a homecoming!
- 12 But if their transgression means riches for the world, and their loss means riches for the Gentiles, how much greater riches will their fullness bring!
- 13 But I don't want to go on about them. It's you, the outsiders, that I'm concerned with now. Because my personal assignment is focused on the so-called outsiders, I make as much of this as I can

- 13 I am talking to you Gentiles. Inasmuch as I am the apostle to the Gentiles, I make much of my ministry
- 14 when I'm among my Israelite kin, the so-called insiders, hoping they'll realize what they're missing and want to get in on what God is doing.
- 14 in the hope that I may somehow arouse my own people to envy and save some of them.
- 15 If their falling out initiated this worldwide coming together, their recovery is going to set off something even better: mass homecoming! If the first thing the Jews did, even though it was wrong for them, turned out for your good, just think what's going to happen when they get it right!
- 15 For if their rejection is the reconciliation of the world, what will their acceptance be but life from the dead?
- 16 Behind and underneath all this there is a holy, God-planted, God-tended root. If the primary root of the tree is holy, there's bound to be some holy fruit.
- 16 If the part of the dough offered as firstfruits is holy, then the whole batch is holy; if the root is holy, so are the branches.
- 17 Some of the tree's branches were pruned and you wild olive shoots were grafted in. Yet the fact that you are now fed by that rich and holy root
- 17 If some of the branches have been broken off, and you, though a wild olive shoot, have been grafted in among the others and now share in the nourishing sap from the olive root,
- 18 gives you no cause to crow over the pruned branches. Remember, you aren't feeding the root; the root is feeding you.
- 18 do not boast over those branches. If you do, consider this: You do not support the root, but the root supports you.
- 19 It's certainly possible to say, "Other branches were pruned so that I could be grafted in!"
- 19 You will say then, "Branches were broken off so that I could be grafted in."
- 20 Well and good. But they were pruned because they were deadwood, no longer connected by belief and commitment to the root. The only reason you're on the tree is because your graft "took" when you believed, and because you're connected to that belief-nurturing root. So don't get cocky

and strut your branch. Be humbly mindful of the root that keeps you lithe and green.

20 Granted. But they were broken off because of unbelief, and you stand by faith. Do not be arrogant, but be afraid.

21 If God didn't think twice about taking pruning shears to the natural branches, why would he hesitate over you? He wouldn't give it a second thought.

21 For if God did not spare the natural branches, he will not spare you either.

22 Make sure you stay alert to these qualities of gentle kindness and ruthless severity that exist side by side in God--ruthless with the deadwood, gentle with the grafted shoot. But don't presume on this gentleness. The moment you become deadwood, you're out of there.

22 Consider therefore the kindness and sternness of God: sternness to those who fell, but kindness to you, provided that you continue in his kindness. Otherwise, you also will be cut off.

23 And don't get to feeling superior to those pruned branches down on the ground. If they don't persist in remaining deadwood, they could very well get grafted back in. God can do that. He can perform miracle grafts.

23 And if they do not persist in unbelief, they will be grafted in, for God is able to graft them in again.

24 Why, if he could graft you--branches cut from a tree out in the wild--into an orchard tree, he certainly isn't going to have any trouble grafting branches back into the tree they grew from in the first place. Just be glad you're in the tree, and hope for the best for the others.

24 After all, if you were cut out of an olive tree that is wild by nature, and contrary to nature were grafted into a cultivated olive tree, how much more readily will these, the natural branches, be grafted into their own olive tree!

25 I want to lay all this out on the table as clearly as I can, friends. This is complicated. It would be easy to misinterpret what's going on and arrogantly assume that you're royalty and they're just rabble, out on their ears for good. But that's not it at all. This hardness on the part of insider Israel toward God is temporary. Its effect is to open things up to all the outsiders so that we end up with a full house.

- 25 I do not want you to be ignorant of this mystery, brothers, so that you may not be conceited: Israel has experienced a hardening in part until the full number of the Gentiles has come in.
- 26 Before it's all over, there will be a complete Israel. As it is written, A champion will stride down from the mountain of Zion; he'll clean house in Jacob.
- 26 And so all Israel will be saved, as it is written: "The deliverer will come from Zion; he will turn godlessness away from Jacob.
- 27 And this is my commitment to my people: removal of their sins.
- 27 And this is my covenant with them when I take away their sins."
- 28 From your point of view as you hear and embrace the good news of the Message, it looks like the Jews are God's enemies. But looked at from the long-range perspective of God's overall purpose, they remain God's oldest friends.
- 28 As far as the gospel is concerned, they are enemies on your account; but as far as election is concerned, they are loved on account of the patriarchs,
- 29 God's gifts and God's call are under full warranty--never canceled, never rescinded.
- 29 for God's gifts and his call are irrevocable.
- 30 There was a time not so long ago when you were on the outs with God. But then the Jews slammed the door on him and things opened up for you.
- 30 Just as you who were at one time disobedient to God have now received mercy as a result of their disobedience,
- 31 Now they are on the outs. But with the door held wide open for you, they have a way back in.
- 31 so they too have now become disobedient in order that they too may now receive mercy as a result of God's mercy to you.
- 32 In one way or another, God makes sure that we all experience what it means to be outside so that he can personally open the door and welcome us back in.
- 32 For God has bound all men over to disobedience so that he may have mercy on them all.
- 33 Have you ever come on anything quite like this extravagant generosity of God, this deep, deep wisdom? It's way over our heads. We'll never

figure it out.

- 33 Oh, the depth of the riches of the wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable his judgments, and his paths beyond tracing out!
- 34 Is there anyone around who can explain God? Anyone smart enough to tell him what to do?
- 34 Who has known the mind of the Lord? Or who has been his counselor?
- 35 Anyone who has done him such a huge favor that God has to ask his advice?
- 35 Who has ever given to God, that God should repay him?
- 36 Everything comes from him; Everything happens through him; Everything ends up in him. Always glory! Always praise! Yes. Yes. Yes.
- 36 For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be the glory forever! Amen.

## **Romans 12**

MSG

NIV

- 1 So here's what I want you to do, God helping you: Take your everyday, ordinary life--your sleeping, eating, going-to-work, and walking-around life--and place it before God as an offering. Embracing what God does for you is the best thing you can do for him.
- 1 Therefore, I urge you, brothers, in view of God's mercy, to offer your bodies as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God--this is your spiritual act of worship.
- 2 Don't become so well-adjusted to your culture that you fit into it without even thinking. Instead, fix your attention on God. You'll be changed from the inside out. Readily recognize what he wants from you, and quickly respond to it. Unlike the culture around you, always dragging you down to its level of immaturity, God brings the best out of you, develops well-formed maturity in you.
- 2 Do not conform any longer to the pattern of this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what God's will is-- his good, pleasing and perfect will.
- 3 I'm speaking to you out of deep gratitude for all that God has given me, and especially as I have responsibilities in relation to you. Living then,

as every one of you does, in pure grace, it's important that you not misinterpret yourselves as people who are bringing this goodness to God. No, God brings it all to you. The only accurate way to understand ourselves is by what God is and by what he does for us, not by what we are and what we do for him.

- 3 For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but rather think of yourself with sober judgment, in accordance with the measure of faith God has given you.
- 4 In this way we are like the various parts of a human body. Each part gets its meaning from the body as a whole, not the other way around.
- 4 Just as each of us has one body with many members, and these members do not all have the same function,
- 5 The body we're talking about is Christ's body of chosen people. Each of us finds our meaning and function as a part of his body. But as a chopped-off finger or cut-off toe we wouldn't amount to much, would we? So since we find ourselves fashioned into all these excellently formed and marvelously functioning parts in Christ's body,
- 5 so in Christ we who are many form one body, and each member belongs to all the others.
- 6 let's just go ahead and be what we were made to be, without enviously or pridefully comparing ourselves with each other, or trying to be something we aren't. If you preach, just preach God's Message, nothing else;
- 6 We have different gifts, according to the grace given us. If a man's gift is prophesying, let him use it in proportion to his faith.
- 7 if you help, just help, don't take over; if you teach, stick to your teaching;
- 7 If it is serving, let him serve; if it is teaching, let him teach;
- 8 if you give encouraging guidance, be careful that you don't get bossy; if you're put in charge, don't manipulate; if you're called to give aid to people in distress, keep your eyes open and be quick to respond; if you work with the disadvantaged, don't let yourself get irritated with them or depressed by them. Keep a smile on your face.
- 8 if it is encouraging, let him encourage; if it is contributing to the needs of others, let him give generously; if it is leadership, let him govern diligently; if it is showing mercy, let him do it cheerfully.

- 9 Love from the center of who you are; don't fake it. Run for dear life from evil; hold on for dear life to good.
- 9 Love must be sincere. Hate what is evil; cling to what is good.
- 10 Be good friends who love deeply; practice playing second fiddle.
- 10 Be devoted to one another in brotherly love. Honor one another above yourselves.
- 11 Don't burn out; keep yourselves fueled and aflame. Be alert servants of the Master,
- 11 Never be lacking in zeal, but keep your spiritual fervor, serving the Lord.
- 12 cheerfully expectant. Don't quit in hard times; pray all the harder.
- 12 Be joyful in hope, patient in affliction, faithful in prayer.
- 13 Help needy Christians; be inventive in hospitality.
- 13 Share with God's people who are in need. Practice hospitality.
- 14 Bless your enemies; no cursing under your breath.
- 14 Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse.
- 15 Laugh with your happy friends when they're happy; share tears when they're down.
- 15 Rejoice with those who rejoice; mourn with those who mourn.
- 16 Get along with each other; don't be stuck-up. Make friends with nobodies; don't be the great somebody.
- 16 Live in harmony with one another. Do not be proud, but be willing to associate with people of low position. Do not be conceited.
- 17 Don't hit back; discover beauty in everyone.
- 17 Do not repay anyone evil for evil. Be careful to do what is right in the eyes of everybody.
- 18 If you've got it in you, get along with everybody.
- 18 If it is possible, as far as it depends on you, live at peace with everyone.
- 19 Don't insist on getting even; that's not for you to do. "I'll do the judging," says God. "I'll take care of it."
- 19 Do not take revenge, my friends, but leave room for God's wrath, for it is written: "It is mine to avenge; I will repay," says the Lord.
- 20 Our Scriptures tell us that if you see your enemy hungry, go buy that person lunch, or if he's thirsty, get him a drink. Your generosity will surprise him with goodness.

- 20 On the contrary: "If your enemy is hungry, feed him; if he is thirsty, give him something to drink. In doing this, you will heap burning coals on his head."
- 21 Don't let evil get the best of you; get the best of evil by doing good.
- 21 Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.

## **Romans 13**

MSG

NIV

- 1 Be a good citizen. All governments are under God. Insofar as there is peace and order, it's God's order. So live responsibly as a citizen.
- 1 Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which God has established. The authorities that exist have been established by God.
- 2 If you're irresponsible to the state, then you're irresponsible with God, and God will hold you responsible.
- 2 Consequently, he who rebels against the authority is rebelling against what God has instituted, and those who do so will bring judgment on themselves.
- 3 Duly constituted authorities are only a threat if you're trying to get by with something. Decent citizens should have nothing to fear. Do you want to be on good terms with the government? Be a responsible citizen and you'll get on just fine,
- 3 For rulers hold no terror for those who do right, but for those who do wrong. Do you want to be free from fear of the one in authority? Then do what is right and he will commend you.
- 4 the government working to your advantage. But if you're breaking the rules right and left, watch out. The police aren't there just to be admired in their uniforms. God also has an interest in keeping order, and he uses them to do it.
- 4 For he is God's servant to do you good. But if you do wrong, be afraid, for he does not bear the sword for nothing. He is God's servant, an agent of wrath to bring punishment on the wrongdoer.
- 5 That's why you must live responsibly--not just to avoid punishment but also because it's the right way to live.

- 5 Therefore, it is necessary to submit to the authorities, not only because of possible punishment but also because of conscience.
- 6 That's also why you pay taxes--so that an orderly way of life can be maintained.
- 6 This is also why you pay taxes, for the authorities are God's servants, who give their full time to governing.
- 7 Fulfill your obligations as a citizen. Pay your taxes, pay your bills, respect your leaders.
- 7 Give everyone what you owe him: If you owe taxes, pay taxes; if revenue, then revenue; if respect, then respect; if honor, then honor.
- 8 Don't run up debts, except for the huge debt of love you owe each other. When you love others, you complete what the law has been after all along.
- 8 Let no debt remain outstanding, except the continuing debt to love one another, for he who loves his fellowman has fulfilled the law.
- 9 The law code--don't sleep with another person's spouse, don't take someone's life, don't take what isn't yours, don't always be wanting what you don't have, and any other "don't" you can think of--finally adds up to this: Love other people as well as you do yourself.
- 9 The commandments, "Do not commit adultery," "Do not murder," "Do not steal," "Do not covet," and whatever other commandment there may be, are summed up in this one rule: "Love your neighbor as yourself."
- 10 You can't go wrong when you love others. When you add up everything in the law code, the sum total is love.
- 10 Love does no harm to its neighbor. Therefore love is the fulfillment of the law.
- 11 But make sure that you don't get so absorbed and exhausted in taking care of all your day-by-day obligations that you lose track of the time and doze off, oblivious to God.
- 11 And do this, understanding the present time. The hour has come for you to wake up from your slumber, because our salvation is nearer now than when we first believed.
- 12 The night is about over, dawn is about to break. Be up and awake to what God is doing! God is putting the finishing touches on the salvation work he began when we first believed.

- 12 The night is nearly over; the day is almost here. So let us put aside the deeds of darkness and put on the armor of light.
- 13 We can't afford to waste a minute, must not squander these precious daylight hours in frivolity and indulgence, in sleeping around and dissipation, in bickering and grabbing everything in sight.
- 13 Let us behave decently, as in the daytime, not in orgies and drunkenness, not in sexual immorality and debauchery, not in dissension and jealousy.
- 14 Get out of bed and get dressed! Don't loiter and linger, waiting until the very last minute. Dress yourselves in Christ, and be up and about!
- 14 Rather, clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ, and do not think about how to gratify the desires of the sinful nature.

## **Romans 14**

MSG

NIV

- 1 Welcome with open arms fellow believers who don't see things the way you do. And don't jump all over them every time they do or say something you don't agree with--even when it seems that they are strong on opinions but weak in the faith department. Remember, they have their own history to deal with. Treat them gently.
- 1 Accept him whose faith is weak, without passing judgment on disputable matters.
- 2 For instance, a person who has been around for a while might well be convinced that he can eat anything on the table, while another, with a different background, might assume all Christians should be vegetarians and eat accordingly.
- 2 One man's faith allows him to eat everything, but another man, whose faith is weak, eats only vegetables.
- 3 But since both are guests at Christ's table, wouldn't it be terribly rude if they fell to criticizing what the other ate or didn't eat? God, after all, invited them both to the table.
- 3 The man who eats everything must not look down on him who does not, and the man who does not eat everything must not condemn the man who does, for God has accepted him.

- 4 Do you have any business crossing people off the guest list or interfering with God's welcome? If there are corrections to be made or manners to be learned, God can handle that without your help.
- 4 Who are you to judge someone else's servant? To his own master he stands or falls. And he will stand, for the Lord is able to make him stand.
- 5 Or, say, one person thinks that some days should be set aside as holy and another thinks that each day is pretty much like any other. There are good reasons either way. So, each person is free to follow the convictions of conscience.
- 5 One man considers one day more sacred than another; another man considers every day alike. Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind.
- 6 What's important in all this is that if you keep a holy day, keep it for God's sake; if you eat meat, eat it to the glory of God and thank God for prime rib; if you're a vegetarian, eat vegetables to the glory of God and thank God for broccoli.
- 6 He who regards one day as special, does so to the Lord. He who eats meat, eats to the Lord, for he gives thanks to God; and he who abstains, does so to the Lord and gives thanks to God.
- 7 None of us are permitted to insist on our own way in these matters.
- 7 For none of us lives to himself alone and none of us dies to himself alone.
- 8 It's God we are answerable to--all the way from life to death and everything in between--not each other.
- 8 If we live, we live to the Lord; and if we die, we die to the Lord. So, whether we live or die, we belong to the Lord.
- 9 That's why Jesus lived and died and then lived again: so that he could be our Master across the entire range of life and death, and free us from the petty tyrannies of each other.
- 9 For this very reason, Christ died and returned to life so that he might be the Lord of both the dead and the living.
- 10 So where does that leave you when you criticize a brother? And where does that leave you when you condescend to a sister? I'd say it leaves you looking pretty silly--or worse. Eventually, we're all going to end up kneeling side by side in the place of judgment, facing God. Your critical

and condescending ways aren't going to improve your position there one bit.

10 You, then, why do you judge your brother? Or why do you look down on your brother? For we will all stand before God's judgment seat.

11 Read it for yourself in Scripture: "As I live and breathe," God says, "every knee will bow before me; Every tongue will tell the honest truth that I and only I am God."

11 It is written: " 'As surely as I live,' says the Lord, 'every knee will bow before me; every tongue will confess to God.' "

12 So tend to your knitting. You've got your hands full just taking care of your own life before God.

12 So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God.

13 Forget about deciding what's right for each other. Here's what you need to be concerned about: that you don't get in the way of someone else, making life more difficult than it already is.

13 Therefore let us stop passing judgment on one another. Instead, make up your mind not to put any stumbling block or obstacle in your brother's way.

14 I'm convinced--Jesus convinced me!--that everything as it is in itself is holy. We, of course, by the way we treat it or talk about it, can contaminate it.

14 As one who is in the Lord Jesus, I am fully convinced that no food is unclean in itself. But if anyone regards something as unclean, then for him it is unclean.

15 If you confuse others by making a big issue over what they eat or don't eat, you're no longer a companion with them in love, are you? These, remember, are persons for whom Christ died. Would you risk sending them to hell over an item in their diet?

15 If your brother is distressed because of what you eat, you are no longer acting in love. Do not by your eating destroy your brother for whom Christ died.

16 Don't you dare let a piece of God-blessed food become an occasion of soul-poisoning!

16 Do not allow what you consider good to be spoken of as evil.

17 God's kingdom isn't a matter of what you put in your stomach, for goodness' sake. It's what God does with your life as he sets it right, puts

- it together, and completes it with joy.
- 17 For the kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking, but of righteousness, peace and joy in the Holy Spirit,
- 18 Your task is to single-mindedly serve Christ. Do that and you'll kill two birds with one stone: pleasing the God above you and proving your worth to the people around you.
- 18 because anyone who serves Christ in this way is pleasing to God and approved by men.
- 19 So let's agree to use all our energy in getting along with each other. Help others with encouraging words;
- 19 Let us therefore make every effort to do what leads to peace and to mutual edification.
- 20 don't drag them down by finding fault. You're certainly not going to permit an argument over what is served or not served at supper to wreck God's work among you, are you? I said it before and I'll say it again: All food is good, but it can turn bad if you use it badly, if you use it to trip others up and send them sprawling.
- 20 Do not destroy the work of God for the sake of food. All food is clean, but it is wrong for a man to eat anything that causes someone else to stumble.
- 21 When you sit down to a meal, your primary concern should not be to feed your own face but to share the life of Jesus. So be sensitive and courteous to the others who are eating. Don't eat or say or do things that might interfere with the free exchange of love.
- 21 It is better not to eat meat or drink wine or to do anything else that will cause your brother to fall.
- 22 Cultivate your own relationship with God, but don't impose it on others. You're fortunate if your behavior and your belief are coherent.
- 22 So whatever you believe about these things keep between yourself and God. Blessed is the man who does not condemn himself by what he approves.
- 23 But if you're not sure, if you notice that you are acting in ways inconsistent with what you believe--some days trying to impose your opinions on others, other days just trying to please them--then you know that you're out of line. If the way you live isn't consistent with what you believe, then it's wrong.

23 But the man who has doubts is condemned if he eats, because his eating is not from faith; and everything that does not come from faith is sin.

## **Romans 15**

MSG

NIV

- 1 Those of us who are strong and able in the faith need to step in and lend a hand to those who falter, and not just do what is most convenient for us. Strength is for service, not status.
- 1 We who are strong ought to bear with the failings of the weak and not to please ourselves.
- 2 Each one of us needs to look after the good of the people around us, asking ourselves, "How can I help?"
- 2 Each of us should please his neighbor for his good, to build him up.
- 3 That's exactly what Jesus did. He didn't make it easy for himself by avoiding people's troubles, but waded right in and helped out. "I took on the troubles of the troubled," is the way Scripture puts it.
- 3 For even Christ did not please himself but, as it is written: "The insults of those who insult you have fallen on me."
- 4 Even if it was written in Scripture long ago, you can be sure it's written for us. God wants the combination of his steady, constant calling and warm, personal counsel in Scripture to come to characterize us, keeping us alert for whatever he will do next.
- 4 For everything that was written in the past was written to teach us, so that through endurance and the encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope.
- 5 May our dependably steady and warmly personal God develop maturity in you so that you get along with each other as well as Jesus gets along with us all.
- 5 May the God who gives endurance and encouragement give you a spirit of unity among yourselves as you follow Christ Jesus,
- 6 Then we'll be a choir--not our voices only, but our very lives singing in harmony in a stunning anthem to the God and Father of our Master Jesus!

- 6 so that with one heart and mouth you may glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- 7 So reach out and welcome one another to God's glory. Jesus did it; now you do it!
- 7 Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring praise to God.
- 8 Jesus, staying true to God's purposes, reached out in a special way to the Jewish insiders so that the old ancestral promises would come true for them.
- 8 For I tell you that Christ has become a servant of the Jews on behalf of God's truth, to confirm the promises made to the patriarchs
- 9 As a result, the non-Jewish outsiders have been able to experience mercy and to show appreciation to God. Just think of all the Scriptures that will come true in what we do! For instance: Then I'll join outsiders in a hymn-sing; I'll sing to your name!
- 9 so that the Gentiles may glorify God for his mercy, as it is written: "Therefore I will praise you among the Gentiles; I will sing hymns to your name."
- 10 And this one: Outsiders and insiders, rejoice together!
- 10 Again, it says, "Rejoice, O Gentiles, with his people."
- 11 And again: People of all nations, celebrate God! All colors and races, give hearty praise!
- 11 And again, "Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles, and sing praises to him, all you peoples."
- 12 And Isaiah's word: There's the root of our ancestor Jesse, breaking through the earth and growing tree tall, Tall enough for everyone everywhere to see and take hope!
- 12 And again, Isaiah says, "The Root of Jesse will spring up, one who will arise to rule over the nations; the Gentiles will hope in him."
- 13 Oh! May the God of green hope fill you up with joy, fill you up with peace, so that your believing lives, filled with the life-giving energy of the Holy Spirit, will brim over with hope!
- 13 May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you trust in him, so that you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit.

- 14 Personally, I've been completely satisfied with who you are and what you are doing. You seem to me to be well-motivated and well-instructed, quite capable of guiding and advising one another.
- 14 I myself am convinced, my brothers, that you yourselves are full of goodness, complete in knowledge and competent to instruct one another.
- 15 So, my dear friends, don't take my rather bold and blunt language as criticism. It's not criticism. I'm simply underlining how very much I need your help in carrying out this highly focused assignment God gave me,
- 15 I have written you quite boldly on some points, as if to remind you of them again, because of the grace God gave me
- 16 this priestly and gospel work of serving the spiritual needs of the non-Jewish outsiders so they can be presented as an acceptable offering to God, made whole and holy by God's Holy Spirit.
- 16 to be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles with the priestly duty of proclaiming the gospel of God, so that the Gentiles might become an offering acceptable to God, sanctified by the Holy Spirit.
- 17 Looking back over what has been accomplished and what I have observed, I must say I am most pleased--in the context of Jesus, I'd even say proud, but only in that context.
- 17 Therefore I glory in Christ Jesus in my service to God.
- 18 I have no interest in giving you a chatty account of my adventures, only the wondrously powerful and transformingly present words and deeds of Christ in me that triggered a believing response among the outsiders.
- 18 I will not venture to speak of anything except what Christ has accomplished through me in leading the Gentiles to obey God by what I have said and done--
- 19 In such ways I have trailblazed a preaching of the Message of Jesus all the way from Jerusalem far into northwestern Greece.
- 19 by the power of signs and miracles, through the power of the Spirit. So from Jerusalem all the way around to Illyricum, I have fully proclaimed the gospel of Christ.
- 20 This has all been pioneer work, bringing the Message only into those places where Jesus was not yet known and worshiped.
- 20 It has always been my ambition to preach the gospel where Christ was not known, so that I would not be building on someone else's foundation.

- 21 My text has been, Those who were never told of him-- they'll see him!  
Those who've never heard of him-- they'll get the message!
- 21 Rather, as it is written: "Those who were not told about him will see,  
and those who have not heard will understand."
- 22 And that's why it has taken me so long to finally get around to coming  
to you.
- 22 This is why I have often been hindered from coming to you.
- 23 But now that there is no more pioneering work to be done in these parts,  
and since I have looked forward to seeing you for many years,
- 23 But now that there is no more place for me to work in these regions, and  
since I have been longing for many years to see you,
- 24 I'm planning my visit. I'm headed for Spain, and expect to stop off on  
the way to enjoy a good visit with you, and eventually have you send me  
off with God's blessing.
- 24 I plan to do so when I go to Spain. I hope to visit you while passing  
through and to have you assist me on my journey there, after I have  
enjoyed your company for a while.
- 25 First, though, I'm going to Jerusalem to deliver a relief offering to the  
Christians there.
- 25 Now, however, I am on my way to Jerusalem in the service of the saints  
there.
- 26 The Greeks--all the way from the Macedonians in the north to the  
Achaians in the south--decided they wanted to take up a collection for  
the poor among the believers in Jerusalem.
- 26 For Macedonia and Achaia were pleased to make a contribution for the  
poor among the saints in Jerusalem.
- 27 They were happy to do this, but it was also their duty. Seeing that they  
got in on all the spiritual gifts that flowed out of the Jerusalem  
community so generously, it is only right that they do what they can to  
relieve their poverty.
- 27 They were pleased to do it, and indeed they owe it to them. For if the  
Gentiles have shared in the Jews' spiritual blessings, they owe it to the  
Jews to share with them their material blessings.
- 28 As soon as I have done this--personally handed over this "fruit basket"--  
I'm off to Spain, with a stopover with you in Rome.

- 28 So after I have completed this task and have made sure that they have received this fruit, I will go to Spain and visit you on the way.
- 29 My hope is that my visit with you is going to be one of Christ's more extravagant blessings.
- 29 I know that when I come to you, I will come in the full measure of the blessing of Christ.
- 30 I have one request, dear friends: Pray for me. Pray strenuously with and for me--to God the Father, through the power of our Master Jesus, through the love of the Spirit--
- 30 I urge you, brothers, by our Lord Jesus Christ and by the love of the Spirit, to join me in my struggle by praying to God for me.
- 31 that I will be delivered from the lions' den of unbelievers in Judea. Pray also that my relief offering to the Jerusalem Christians will be accepted in the spirit in which it is given.
- 31 Pray that I may be rescued from the unbelievers in Judea and that my service in Jerusalem may be acceptable to the saints there,
- 32 Then, God willing, I'll be on my way to you with a light and eager heart, looking forward to being refreshed by your company.
- 32 so that by God's will I may come to you with joy and together with you be refreshed.
- 33 God's peace be with all of you. Oh, yes!
- 33 The God of peace be with you all. Amen.

## **Romans 16**

MSG

NIV

- 1 Be sure to welcome our friend Phoebe in the way of the Master, with all the generous hospitality we Christians are famous for. I heartily endorse both her and her work. She's a key representative of the church at Cenchrea.
- 1 I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a servant of the church in Cenchrea.
- 2 Help her out in whatever she asks. She deserves anything you can do for her. She's helped many a person, including me.
- 2 I ask you to receive her in the Lord in a way worthy of the saints and to give her any help she may need from you, for she has been a great help

- to many people, including me.
- 3 Say hello to Priscilla and Aquila, who have worked hand in hand with me in serving Jesus.
  - 3 Greet Priscilla and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus.
  - 4 They once put their lives on the line for me. And I'm not the only one grateful to them. All the non-Jewish gatherings of believers also owe them plenty,
  - 4 They risked their lives for me. Not only I but all the churches of the Gentiles are grateful to them.
  - 5 to say nothing of the church that meets in their house. Hello to my dear friend Epenetus. He was the very first Christian in the province of Asia.
  - 5 Greet also the church that meets at their house. Greet my dear friend Epenetus, who was the first convert to Christ in the province of Asia.
  - 6 Hello to Mary. What a worker she has turned out to be!
  - 6 Greet Mary, who worked very hard for you.
  - 7 Hello to my cousins Andronicus and Junias. We once shared a jail cell. They were believers in Christ before I was. Both of them are outstanding leaders.
  - 7 Greet Andronicus and Junias, my relatives who have been in prison with me. They are outstanding among the apostles, and they were in Christ before I was.
  - 8 Hello to Ampliatus, my good friend in the family of God.
  - 8 Greet Ampliatus, whom I love in the Lord.
  - 9 Hello to Urbanus, our companion in Christ's work, and my good friend Stachys.
  - 9 Greet Urbanus, our fellow worker in Christ, and my dear friend Stachys.
  - 10 Hello to Apelles, a tried-and-true veteran in following Christ. Hello to the family of Aristobulus.
  - 10 Greet Apelles, tested and approved in Christ. Greet those who belong to the household of Aristobulus.
  - 11 Hello to my cousin Herodion. Hello to those Christians from the family of Narcissus.
  - 11 Greet Herodion, my relative. Greet those in the household of Narcissus who are in the Lord.
  - 12 Hello to Tryphena and Tryphosa--such diligent women in serving the Master. Hello to Persis, a dear friend and hard worker in Christ.

- 12 Greet Tryphena and Tryphosa, those women who work hard in the Lord. Greet my dear friend Persis, another woman who has worked very hard in the Lord.
- 13 Hello to Rufus--a good choice by the Master!--and his mother. She has also been a dear mother to me.
- 13 Greet Rufus, chosen in the Lord, and his mother, who has been a mother to me, too.
- 14 Hello to Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas, and also to all of their families.
- 14 Greet Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas and the brothers with them.
- 15 Hello to Philologus, Julia, Nereus and his sister, and Olympas--and all the Christians who live with them.
- 15 Greet Philologus, Julia, Nereus and his sister, and Olympas and all the saints with them.
- 16 Holy embraces all around! All the churches of Christ send their warmest greetings!
- 16 Greet one another with a holy kiss. All the churches of Christ send greetings.
- 17 One final word of counsel, friends. Keep a sharp eye out for those who take bits and pieces of the teaching that you learned and then use them to make trouble. Give these people a wide berth.
- 17 I urge you, brothers, to watch out for those who cause divisions and put obstacles in your way that are contrary to the teaching you have learned. Keep away from them.
- 18 They have no intention of living for our Master Christ. They're only in this for what they can get out of it, and aren't above using pious sweet talk to dupe unsuspecting innocents.
- 18 For such people are not serving our Lord Christ, but their own appetites. By smooth talk and flattery they deceive the minds of naive people.
- 19 And so while there has never been any question about your honesty in these matters--I couldn't be more proud of you!--I want you also to be smart, making sure every "good" thing is the real thing. Don't be gullible in regard to smooth-talking evil. Stay alert like this,
- 19 Everyone has heard about your obedience, so I am full of joy over you; but I want you to be wise about what is good, and innocent about what is

evil.

20 and before you know it the God of peace will come down on Satan with both feet, stomping him into the dirt. Enjoy the best of Jesus!

20 The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet. The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you.

21 And here are some more greetings from our end. Timothy, my partner in this work, Lucius, and my cousins Jason and Sosipater all said to tell you hello.

21 Timothy, my fellow worker, sends his greetings to you, as do Lucius, Jason and Sosipater, my relatives.

22 I, Tertius, who wrote this letter at Paul's dictation, send you my personal greetings.

22 I, Tertius, who wrote down this letter, greet you in the Lord.

23 Gaius, who is host here to both me and the whole church, wants to be remembered to you. Erastus, the city treasurer, and our good friend Quartus send their greetings.

23 Gaius, whose hospitality I and the whole church here enjoy, sends you his greetings. Erastus, who is the city's director of public works, and our brother Quartus send you their greetings.

24 (OMITTED TEXT)

25 All of our praise rises to the One who is strong enough to make you strong, exactly as preached in Jesus Christ, precisely as revealed in the mystery kept secret for so long

25 Now to him who is able to establish you by my gospel and the proclamation of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery hidden for long ages past,

26 but now an open book through the prophetic Scriptures. All the nations of the world can now know the truth and be brought into obedient belief, carrying out the orders of God, who got all this started, down to the very last letter.

26 but now revealed and made known through the prophetic writings by the command of the eternal God, so that all nations might believe and obey him--

27 All our praise is focused through Jesus on this incomparably wise God!  
Yes!

27 to the only wise God be glory forever through Jesus Christ! Amen.